Analysis of Apartment Building Construction in Toronto*

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As the city of Toronto continues to expand, it demands increasing amounts of housing, which are not being met currently, leaving Toronto in a housing crisis. Our analysis of Toronto apartment construction data compares activity across across four distinct periods: pre-war, post-war, end of century, and modern. Our findings show that that while there is a mild increase in construction in the modern period, it is not nearly as high as the post-war boom, and that the construction of new housing units is not keeping up with demand.

1 Introduction

Following World War II, Toronto experienced a period of prosperity and rapid development (McGillivray and Howarth 2026). Supported by affordable housing policies, the city saw a huge amount of construction, as demand for new housing exploded. The city grew rapidly, and became the largest city in Canada in 1976 (McGillivray and Howarth 2026): this represents the peak of investments in affordable housing ("Fifty Years in the Making of Ontario's Housing Crisis – a Timeline" 2022). In the 80s, the city begins to cut back on affordable housing policies. As a result, the rapid construction of housing of the post-war boom has not been matched in the 21st century, and Toronto now faces a significant housing crisis. Toronto consistently has a higher rate of low-income households than the rest of Canada or Ontario ("Toronto Housing Data Book" 2026). Through a data-driven analysis of the construction of apartment buildings in Toronto, we find that modern efforts by the city are bearing modest fruit, but not nearly to the extent that they would need to in order to meet demand. In 2022 and 2023, Toronto has the highest gross increase in population of any city in North America ("Toronto Tops in 2023 Population Growth in Canada and the United States" 2024), and the construction is simply not keeping up with demand.

*Code and data are available at: https://github.com/baleinegris/TorontoHousingAnalysis.

In this analysis, we present a history of Toronto's housing development, from 1900 to 2020 using data from Open Data Toronto [!Todo cite Open Data Toronto dataset]. We focus only on the construction of apartment buildings, and track their construction over time, as well as their locations and sizes. We find three distinct periods of construction:

- 1900-1945: Pre-war slow development of small apartments in downtown Toronto
- 1945-1979: Post-war boom in construction, characterized by urban sprawl and the construction of mid-sized apartment buildings
- 1980-1999: Decline in construction, as the city begins to repeal housing policies that encouraged the post-war boom
- 2000-2020: Modern period of construction, characterized by a shift towards high-rise apartment buildings in the downtown area, encouraged by new housing policies

2 Data

2.1 Overview

We use the dataset Apartment Building Evaluation from Open Data Toronto [!Todo cite this], obtained through the CKAN API [!Todo cite CKAN API]. This dataset contains information from apartment inspections for buildings registered in RentSafeTO: Apartment Building Standards. RentSafeTO is a bylaw enforcement program founded by the city of Toronto in 2017, and includes all buildings with three or more storeys and 10 or more units. Inspections must occur at least once every two years. The dataset includes information from the inspections themselves, as well as information about the building itself. The inspection method changed in 2023, and so the dataset is downloaded in two parts. For our analysis, we focus only on the information about the building, and not the details of the inspections.

2.2 Measurement

Inspections are conducted by the city each year. A list is made of all buildings requiring an evaluation, the building receives a notice, and a bylaw enforcement is assigned to inspect the building. On the date of the inspction, the officer visits the building, photographing and documenting the state of the building manually. The details of the inspection are then given to the building, who is required to share them with tenants, as well as being added to the public dataset. As such, there is not ethical concern with using this data, as it is already required to be public.

2.3 Cleaning

As mentioned, we did not include information about the inspections themselves. For each building, we kept only the most recent inspection, and then dropped all columns related to the inspection. We kept the following columns:

- **RSN**: a unique identifier for each building
- **units**: the number of units in the building
- **storeys**: the number of storeys in the building
- **year_built**: the year the building was built
- **latitude**: the latitude of the building
- **longitude**: the longitude of the building

Additionally, we only included buildings built between 1900 and 2020. We justify this decision in two ways: firstly, there are very few buildings built prior to 1900, and so their inclusion would not add to our analysis. Secondly, there appears to be a lag between the time when a building is constructed and its addition to the dataset. This is likely because the building must be registered in RentSafeTO, and then inspected at least once before it is added to the dataset. As such, we exclude buildings built after 2020, as the data appears to be incomplete. After cleaning, we are left with 3464 buildings in our dataset.

2.4 Distribution of Data

3 Analysis

4 Conclusion

As Cuberes (2011) notes, "(…) early on in the process of urbanization, the largest cities grow fastest. As time passes, population growth in the larger cities declines and the fastest growth can be found in smaller cities farther down in the urban hierarchy" (Cuberes 2011).

Cuberes, David. 2011. "Sequential City Growth: Empirical Evidence." *Journal of Urban Economics* 69 (2): 229–39. https://doi.org/https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jue.2010.10.002.

"Fifty Years in the Making of Ontario's Housing Crisis – a Timeline." 2022. *Canadian Centre for Housing Rights*. https://housingrightscanada.com/fifty-years-in-the-making-of-ontarios-housing-crisis-a-timeline/.

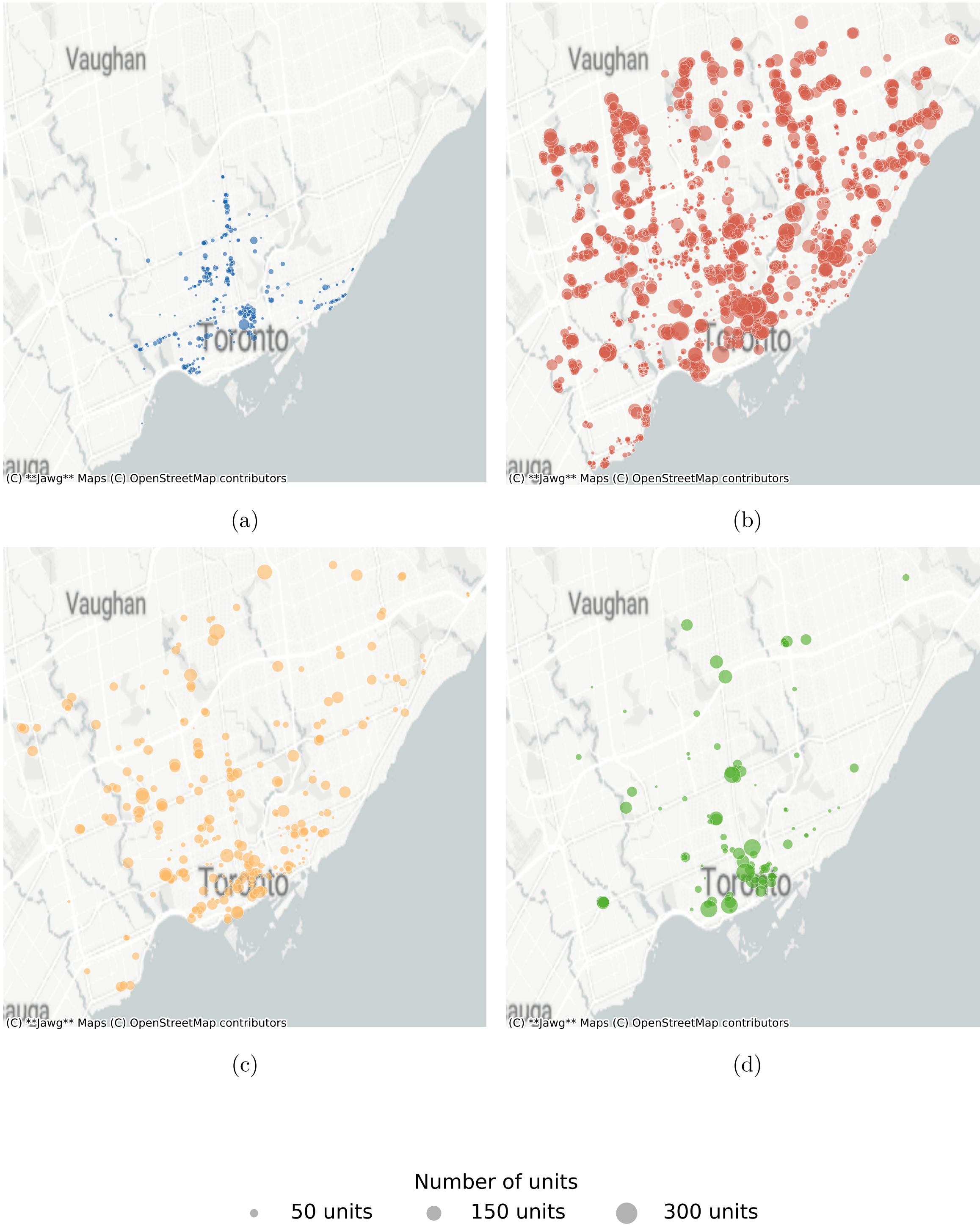

Figure 1: Residential buildings in Toronto by construction era. Bubble size reflects number of units.

McGillivray, Brett, and Thomas Howarth. 2026. "Toronto." *Encyclopedia Britannica*. https://www.britannica.com/place/Toronto.

"Toronto Housing Data Book." 2026. *City of Toronto*. https://toronto.ca/city-government/data-research-maps/toronto-housing-data-book/.

"Toronto Tops in 2023 Population Growth in Canada and the United States." 2024. *Toronto Metropolitan University*. https://www.torontomu.ca/centre-urban-research-land-development/blog/blogentry86-toronto-tops-in-population-growth-in-canada-and-us/.